

## **\*\*Let's Give Children the Best That the Digital Society Has to Offer\*\***

It is not just a matter of writing new rules, but rather of investing, as we have not done so far, in educating young people and adults to be young and adults in the digital dimension and to impose limits—more technological than legal—on the masters of the digital markets.

**\*\*Intervention by Guido Scorza, Member of the Authority for the Protection of Personal Data\*\***  
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In 1924, in Geneva, the international community, by signing the Declaration on the Rights of the Child, promised, among other things, to give the youngest the best that humanity has to offer. Today, we must acknowledge that a hundred years have not been enough for us adults—who, after all, remind the younger generations every day of the importance of keeping promises—to fulfill that promise.

It is worth recalling this on the eve of the World Children's Day established by Pope Francis, which will take place in Rome next weekend, while the European Commission launches one of the fiercest accusations against the social network industry, accusing it of harming children. Meanwhile, the University of Bicocca, in a recently published study, clearly states that the premature entry of our children into social networks undermines, among other things, their learning abilities. Applications based on artificial intelligence, the dynamics of which and their impact on society even the masters of the algorithm factories know less about than would be necessary, are capturing hundreds of millions of children. And, above all, it seems important—and perhaps even necessary—to recall this on the eve of a G7, led by Italy, where artificial intelligence will be a key topic and in which the Pope himself will participate.

A century later, indeed, while we are trying to govern artificial intelligence and, in particular, its impact on the world, humanity has the opportunity to redeem itself, albeit belatedly, and to place, not only and not so much, as is now often repeated in every institutional setting and in every official document, man at the center, but children at the center.

Because those children whom we have forced to grow up in a digital universe that—today we can probably say without appearing heretical as has been the case until now—was never thought out, designed, planned, or built to their measure, have the sacred right to grow up in a world where they can finally have access to the best—artificial intelligence and algorithms included—that humanity has and will have to offer them.

In short, it may be the best moment to renew that now ancient betrayed promise and, at least this time, to truly keep it. However, to succeed in this endeavor, in a world that is moving at an extraordinarily faster pace than that of 1924, mere words are certainly not enough; it is not useful to add more solemn declarations to those that already exist and have remained unfulfilled. Nor is it necessary to identify unbeatable enemies among the masters of new technologies in order to then say that despite efforts, we have failed due to the invincibility of the adversaries who, by the way, are not invincible and, in any case, being governed by people who presumably care about children no less than each of us, can become our best allies at least in this challenge.

On the contrary, we must first take on our responsibilities as adults. We must immediately apologize to children for that betrayed promise and for having handed them technologies capable of offering extraordinary opportunities without, however, doing what would have been necessary for them to take advantage of them in a conscious and sustainable way.

We must return—or perhaps, in many cases, start—to being adults even in the digital dimension, once and for all stopping the narrative that they, the younger ones, are “digital natives” and therefore know more than we do about the “new world” and do not need us, because that is a colossal misunderstanding born of our digital ignorance: knowing how to tap on the screen of a smartphone, as children certainly do better than we do, has nothing to do with being educated in its use.

Why do we teach the youngest to cross asphalt roads and not do the same with digital highways? And then, we must convince ourselves once and for all that in the digital dimension not everything is for

everyone and that just as we would never allow our child—at least most of us would never do so—to ride a scooter without being of the legal age or to do so without a helmet, we should never allow our child to enter, while still a child, a digital platform that is not only structurally unsuitable for their age but whose operator, always writing with great timidity but with increasing visibility, states that entry is reserved for those of a certain age.

Yet there are millions of parents who accompany their under-thirteen children to platforms where the sign reads: access reserved for those over thirteen. And those among us who do not do so often watch their under-thirteen children frolicking on those same platforms, spending an increasing part of their days there, sharing an enormous amount of their personal data without questioning how they got in and whether they could have done so without lying about their age.

Naturally, this will not be enough to keep the youngest out of digital platforms not designed for them. It will not be enough until we are able to demand from digital operators what should have been natural from the very first day of their platforms' existence: to do what, in every amusement park, the operator who knows that the safety belts of the carriage of his roller coaster are designed to secure only those who are less than one meter tall is called to do, namely, to measure the height of those who board. And it does not matter if this has a cost and if it involves giving up hundreds of millions of child users and thus a mountain of money.

It is undoubtedly worth it.

We must ensure that we no longer see children using digital services, whether based on artificial intelligence or not, designed for adults or, simply, for those who are more adult, and to achieve this, we must demand the immediate implementation of technological solutions capable of guaranteeing this result.

There is also another central issue to make the digital future and differently intelligent better and more sustainable than the past, primarily for the youngest: we must not fall into the trap of confusing the ease and immediacy of use (the so-called usability) of digital services and devices, including those based on artificial intelligence, with their harmlessness, with their non-dangerousness, with their actual possibility of simple, conscious, and safe use.

Usability has been and continues to be the secret weapon of the protagonists of digital markets to conquer billions of users, to capture enormous amounts of their time and attention, and to fill their coffers with an extraordinary amount of data and personal information, all factors through which they have achieved now uncontested positions in the financial, commercial, and political dimensions.

Of course, it would be a mistake to take issue with usability, which, at the same time, has given billions of users the opportunity to use technologies that, otherwise, few of us would have used, witnessing a dramatic widening of the divides and discriminations already present in global society.

And yet, it cannot be that while a motorcycle or car dealer does not allow the buyer to take the wheel without first showing him the license and insurance, the operator of a platform, service, or digital device not only does not have to do the same but, on the contrary, can freely suggest that their services are simple and quick to use and are accessible to anyone, without the need for warnings, instructions, or any kind of knowledge.

Taking control of an artificial intelligence service with which one can produce any kind of content or a social networking or messaging service with which one can share that content with billions of people can no longer be considered less dangerous than driving a motorcycle or a car.

Unfortunately, we have seen that both activities produce millions of victims around the world every year, often victims whose lives yet to be lived could have been significantly longer than the lives they lived or, more simply, of extraordinarily higher quality.

There is still so much to do in this direction. It is not just a matter of writing new rules, but of investing as has not been done so far in educating young people and adults to be young and adults in the digital dimension and to impose limits, more technological than legal, on the masters of digital markets,

accepting the fact that not everything that is technologically possible is, always, also legally legitimate and democratically sustainable, and when the well-being of the youngest is at stake, it can never be so if the fact that it is does not serve the best interest of the child.

If we unite the forces of adults and, for once, a hundred years later, truly make it a government priority to give children the best that humanity has to offer, this challenge can be won.